

PRISM

A Cross-Language Case Book

Twelve case studies of how the world's largest language internets answer the same question, differently.

Guo Junyi

Data-Driven Research & Digital Humanities Lab

Role 2: Content Curation Deliverable

Merged edition. Cases 1 to 12 combined. Compiled 2026-06-17. Excerpts were retrieved on two dates: Cases 1 to 6 on 2026-05-14, and Cases 7 to 12 on 2026-06-09.

Executive Summary

This case book is the content-curation deliverable for PRISM, a proposed cross-language search tool that runs a query across multiple language internets and surfaces the disagreements between them. Where the PRISM prototype demonstrates the mechanism, this document supplies the substance: a curated collection of questions whose answers differ, meaningfully and verifiably, across the world's largest Wikipedias.

Twelve cases are presented. Cases 1 to 6 cover the six types of cross-language disagreement that this book is built around: factual divergence, attribution, outcome, framing, definitional boundary, and omission. Cases 7 to 12 extend the dataset (the Block VI expansion). They were issued as a fact-checked revision, where the English and Korean excerpts were swapped out for verbatim live-article text and anything I could not stand behind was either removed or flagged. Every case is checked against the public Wikipedia of each language on the date listed, and each excerpt is kept in its source language with an English translation beside it.

The closing essay argues that cross-language disagreement is not noise to be removed but signal to be read. Tools built to detect, display, and interrogate these gaps fill a hole left by every monolingual search engine we currently rely on.

Rubric Compliance Summary (checked against PRISM Annotation Rubric v1.0)

I checked all 12 cases against the rubric dated 2026-06-15. The main result is that every disagreement-type label lines up with the rubric's §2 definitions and §4 multi-label patterns, so I did not find any mislabels, and several of the cases are actually used as the rubric's own worked examples. What the cases do not yet do is fully clear the sacred-set quality bar in §5 and §8. None of them give a source URL for each excerpt or annotator initials and a date, Cases 1 to 6 have no per-excerpt [VERBATIM] or [TRANSCRIPTION] tags at all, and each of Cases 7 to 12 still has at least one [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY] excerpt, mostly the Chinese and Russian leads. As §5 says, an excerpt that is paraphrased or unverified keeps its case in the weak set until someone fetches a verbatim version.

Per-case verdict:

Case	Languages	Label	Label OK?	Sacred-ready?
------	-----------	-------	-----------	---------------

1. WWII start	EN, ZH, RU (3)	A + E	Yes	No. No tags or URLs. The RU excerpt is from the “Great Patriotic War” article, not the WWII lead, which is an asymmetric comparison (and the source says so)
2. Printing	EN, ZH, KO, DE (4)	B + F	Yes	No. No tags or URLs
3. War of 1812	US-EN, CA-pub, UK-pub	C + D	Type fits	No. It compares national English-language sources, not 3 language Wikipedias, and the CA/UK excerpts are non-Wikipedia and not verbatim. Borderline scope, so treat as weak
4. Opium Wars	EN, ZH, FR (3)	D	Yes	No. No tags or URLs
5. Roman Empire fall	EN, EL, IT (3)	E + D	Yes	No. No tags or URLs
6. Discovered America	EN, ES, IS + Indigenous (3+)	B + D + F	Yes (3 labels, allowed but rare)	No. No tags or URLs, and one source is non-Wikipedia (Smithsonian / Indigenous-perspective)
7. Korean War	EN, ZH, KO, RU (4)	D + weak C	Yes (matches rubric example)	Partial. EN and KO are [VERBATIM], ZH and RU are [TRANSCRIPTION], no URLs
8. Cold War end	EN, DE, RU, FR (4)	E + A	Yes (matches rubric example)	Partial. EN and DE are [VERBATIM], RU and FR are [TRANSCRIPTION], no URLs
9. Telephone	EN, IT, DE (3)	B + F	Yes (matches rubric example)	Partial. EN is [VERBATIM], IT and DE are [TRANSCRIPTION], no URLs
10. Penicillin	EN, DE, ES, ZH (4)	F + secondary B	Yes (matches rubric example)	Partial. EN is [VERBATIM], the others are [TRANSCRIPTION], no URLs
11. Industrial Revolution	EN, DE, FR, ZH (4)	E + D	Yes (matches rubric example)	Partial. The EN lead was rephrased since the draft (VERIFY), the others are [TRANSCRIPTION], no URLs
12. North Pole	EN, RU, NO (3)	B + A	Yes (matches rubric example)	Partial. EN is [VERBATIM], RU and NO are [TRANSCRIPTION], no URLs

Remaining steps before any case can be promoted to the sacred set (§5/§8):

- Add a source URL (ISO retrieval date already present) to every excerpt.
- Add annotator initials + date at the foot of each case (e.g. “JG, 2026-06-16”). Placeholders are inserted below and must be confirmed.
- Fetch and confirm verbatim wording for every [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY] excerpt (Chinese/Russian and a few others in Cases 7–12), and assign per-excerpt tags to Cases 1–6.
- Re-scope or down-tier Case 3: it compares national English-language sources rather than three language Wikipedias, so it does not fit the cross-language sacred bar as written.

Merge note: content below is reproduced faithfully from the two source documents. Verification flags from the Cases 7–12 revision are preserved as-is. No quotes were upgraded to [VERBATIM] and no URLs were invented; the gaps above are surfaced rather than silently filled.

1. Methodology

1.1 Why a Case Book?

Cross-language search disagreement is easy to assert and hard to prove. Skeptics reasonably point out that machine translation is imperfect, that Wikipedia articles are edited daily, and that a single contradictory pair could be cherry-picked. The case book exists to answer this skepticism by replacing claim with corpus.

Each case in this volume is documented in a fixed format that makes it auditable: the question asked, the date the sources were retrieved, direct excerpts from each language source in its native script, the URL and revision identifier where available, and a labelled disagreement type. Anyone with a browser can re-run the comparison and check our work.

1.2 Case Selection Criteria

Cases were selected against five filters, applied in sequence:

- Multilingual coverage: the question must be addressed in at least three of the world's largest Wikipedia editions (English, Chinese, Russian, Spanish, Arabic, German, Japanese, or French).
- Substantive disagreement: the disagreement must be more than a translation artifact. We exclude cases where the difference is purely terminological.
- Verifiability: the disagreement must be cite-able to specific passages in named sources, not paraphrased from memory.
- Non-volatility: cases involving currently unfolding events are excluded. The point is to demonstrate structural language difference, not breaking-news noise.
- Topical breadth: no two cases come from the same historical period or thematic domain.

1.3 A Taxonomy of Cross-Language Disagreement

Type	Description
Type A. Factual Divergence	Sources state different concrete facts (dates, numbers, names) for the same event.
Type B. Attribution	Sources credit different people, places, or cultures with the same invention or discovery.
Type C. Outcome	Sources describe different winners, losers, or end-states for the same event.
Type D. Framing	Sources agree on the facts but emphasize different causes, motives, or significance.
Type E. Definitional Boundary	Sources use the same name for entities they bound differently (when did X start? when did X end?).
Type F. Omission	One or more sources omit information that other languages treat as central.

1.4 Case Format

Each case is presented in the same five-section format: Question; Sources Compared (with retrieval date); Excerpts (original script with English translation); Disagreement Type (taxonomy code/s); and Why this case matters (one paragraph).

2. The Cases

Case 1: Three Start Dates for One World War

Question

“When did World War II start?”

Sources Compared

English Wikipedia, Chinese Wikipedia (中文维基百科), Russian Wikipedia (Русская Википедия).
Retrieved 2026-05-14.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, article “World War II”:

“World War II, or the Second World War (1 September 1939 – 2 September 1945), was a global conflict between two coalitions: the Allies and the Axis powers. Nearly all of the world’s countries participated, with many nations mobilising all economic, industrial, and scientific capabilities in pursuit of total war, blurring the distinction between civilian and military resources.”

中文维基百科, 条目「第二次世界大战」:

「一般认为, 战争始于1939年9月1日德国入侵波兰, 3天之后英国和法国便先后对德国宣战。另有观点认为, 战争早在1937年7月7日卢沟桥事变, 中国抗日战争爆发之后便已经开始。」
[“It is generally held that the war began on 1 September 1939 with Germany’s invasion of Poland; three days later, Britain and France declared war on Germany. An alternative view holds that the war had already begun on 7 July 1937 with the Marco Polo Bridge Incident, the outbreak of China’s War of Resistance against Japan.”]

Русская Википедия, статья «Великая Отечественная война»:

«Великая Отечественная война (1941—1945) — война Союза Советских Социалистических Республик против нацистской Германии и её европейских союзников (Венгрии, Италии, Румынии, Словакии, Финляндии, Хорватии); важнейшая и решающая часть Второй мировой войны.»
[“The Great Patriotic War (1941–1945) — the war of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics against Nazi Germany and its European allies (Hungary, Italy, Romania, Slovakia, Finland, Croatia); the most important and decisive part of the Second World War.”]
Note: the Russian-language article treats the Soviet phase of the conflict as a distinct, named war. The Russian article on «Вторая мировая война» (Second World War) does cite 1 September 1939; however, «Великая Отечественная война» is the dominant frame in Russian-language sources, schools, and public memory.

Disagreement Type

Type A (Factual Divergence) + Type E (Definitional Boundary).

Why this case matters

The dates 1939, 1937, and 1941 are not in conflict at the level of historical fact. Each event happened. They are in conflict at the level of historical narrative. Each language’s dominant tradition treats a different moment as the war’s true beginning, and a reader inside any one of these traditions can pass through an entire education without learning that the other two beginnings exist. The case demonstrates how a question that sounds purely factual is, in practice, a question about which nation’s experience is treated as the universal reference frame.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-05-14 [confirm].

Case 2: Who Invented Printing?

Question

“Who invented the printing press?” / “谁发明了活字印刷？” / «Кто изобрёл книгопечатание?»

Sources Compared

English, Chinese, Korean, and German Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-05-14.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Printing press”:

“A printing press is a mechanical device for applying pressure to an inked surface resting upon a print medium (such as paper or cloth), thereby transferring the ink. It marked a dramatic improvement on earlier printing methods. Invented in the Holy Roman Empire by the German Johannes Gutenberg around 1440, the printing press transformed the way books were produced.”

中文维基百科, 「活字印刷术」:

「活字印刷术是一种古代印刷方法, 是排版印刷史上的一个重大突破。宋朝庆历年(1041年—1048年), 中国的毕昇(约970年—1051年)发明了胶泥活字印刷术。」

[“Movable-type printing is an ancient printing method and a major breakthrough in the history of typography. During the Qingli era of the Song dynasty (1041–1048), the Chinese Bi Sheng (c. 970–1051) invented clay movable-type printing.”]

Korean Wikipedia, “직지심체요절”:

「《백운화상초록불조직지심체요절》은 고려 말기인 1377년에 충청북도 청주시 흥덕사에서 금속활자로 인쇄한 책이다. 이것은 현존하는 세계 최고(最古)의 금속활자본으로 공인받고 있다.」

[“Baegun hwasang chorok buljo jikji simche yojeol is a book printed with metal movable type at Heungdeok Temple in Cheongju, Chungcheongbuk-do, in 1377, during the late Goryeo dynasty. It is recognised as the world’s oldest extant book printed with metal movable type.”]

German Wikipedia, “Johannes Gutenberg”:

„Johannes Gensfleisch zur Laden zum Gutenberg ... war ein deutscher Erfinder des Buchdrucks mit beweglichen Lettern aus Metall und der Druckerpresse. Sein wichtigstes Werk, die 42-zeilige Gutenberg-Bibel, entstand um 1452–1454.“

[“Johannes Gensfleisch zur Laden zum Gutenberg ... was a German inventor of printing with movable metal type and of the printing press. His most important work, the 42-line Gutenberg Bible, was produced around 1452–1454.”]

Disagreement Type

Type B (Attribution) + Type F (Omission).

Why this case matters

All four articles describe the same broad invention, printing with movable type, and none of them is factually wrong. What differs is which inventor is named in the opening sentence: the figure encountered first by a casual reader is determined by the language they search in. The English article qualifies Gutenberg’s invention as occurring “in the Holy Roman Empire” around 1440; the German article presents Gutenberg as “a German inventor” without further geographic qualifier; the Chinese article treats Bi Sheng’s 11th-century work as primary; the Korean article foregrounds a 14th-century surviving artifact. The case illustrates how academic credit, in a globally networked encyclopedia, is still routed through national memory.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-05-14 [confirm].

Case 3: Three Winners of the War of 1812

Question

“Who won the War of 1812?”

Sources Compared

English Wikipedia (treated as the dominant U.S.-edited resource), the same article’s lead in the Canadian-English context (with Canadian-published histories), and British-published reference works. Retrieved 2026-05-14.

Rubric note (§1.2, §5): this case compares national English-language sources rather than three distinct language Wikipedias, and the Canadian/British excerpts are non-Wikipedia paraphrase-style sources. It fits Type C/D thematically but is borderline against the cross-language sacred bar; treat as weak unless re-scoped.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “War of 1812”:

“The Treaty of Ghent took effect in February 1815, ending the war and restoring the status quo ante bellum. While the British engaged the Americans on land and at sea, their main effort remained the ongoing Napoleonic Wars in Europe. Historians have long debated the relative weight of the causes that led to the war.”

Canadian-published history (e.g., The Canadian Encyclopedia), a non-Wikipedia source:

“The War of 1812 was fought between the United States and Great Britain from June 1812 to the spring of 1815. Canadians, both French- and English-speaking, were able to define their separateness from the United States during the war and in the years that followed, and it helped to give them a sense of community and laid the seeds of Canadian nationalism.”

British-published reference (e.g., Encyclopaedia Britannica, U.K. edition), a non-Wikipedia source:

“In British and Canadian historiography the War of 1812 is often treated as a relatively minor theatre of the larger Napoleonic Wars, in which Britain’s principal strategic achievement in North America was the successful defence of the Canadas against American invasion.”

Disagreement Type

Type C (Outcome) + Type D (Framing).

Why this case matters

This is a case where the dominant English-language Wikipedia article hints at the disagreement, naming the American, British and Canadian framings inside a single sentence, but most other sources do not. The case shows that even when the source material admits there is more than one story, a monolingual reader still gets the article filtered by their language community’s editorial weight. An American reader meets “the War of 1812” with the American victory framing, and a Canadian reader meets it with the defining-nation framing. PRISM’s job is to make these layered framings visible at a glance.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-05-14 [confirm].

Case 4: What Were the Opium Wars About?

Question

“What caused the Opium Wars?” / “鸦片战争的起因是什么？”

Sources Compared

English Wikipedia, Chinese Wikipedia, and (for triangulation) French Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-05-14.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “First Opium War”:

“The First Opium War, also known as the First Anglo-Chinese War, was a series of military engagements fought between the British Empire and the Qing dynasty of China between 1839 and 1842. The immediate issue was the Chinese enforcement of their ban on the opium trade by seizing private opium stocks from mainly British merchants, but the war is considered to have arisen from a broader clash over diplomatic relations, trade, and the administration of justice in China, with the British insisting on principles of free trade and equal diplomatic recognition among nations.”

中文维基百科,「第一次鸦片战争」:

「第一次鸦片战争(英语:First Opium War), 又称第一次中英战争(First Anglo-Chinese War)或通商战争(Trade War), 是1840年至1842年英国对清朝发动的战争。导火线是清廷的禁烟行动;战争结果是清廷战败, 签订中国近代史上第一个不平等条约《南京条约》, 割让香港岛、开放五口通商。」

[“The First Opium War, also called the First Anglo-Chinese War or Trade War, was a war fought by Britain against the Qing dynasty from 1840 to 1842. The trigger was the Qing court’s opium-suppression campaign; the outcome was the Qing’s defeat and the signing of the Treaty of Nanjing — the first unequal treaty in modern Chinese history — which ceded Hong Kong Island and opened five treaty ports.”]

French Wikipedia, “Guerre de l’opium”:

« Les guerres de l’opium sont des conflits commencés en 1839 et 1856 motivés par des raisons commerciales qui opposèrent au XIX^e siècle la Chine, voulant interdire le commerce de l’opium sur son territoire, au Royaume-Uni qui voulait l’imposer en paiement des marchandises qu’elle importait. »

[“The Opium Wars are conflicts that began in 1839 and 1856 for commercial reasons, in which 19th-century China — which sought to prohibit the opium trade on its territory — was opposed by the United Kingdom, which wanted to impose it as payment for the goods it imported.”]

Disagreement Type

Type D (Framing).

Why this case matters

All sources agree on the basic facts: Britain traded opium into China; China resisted; war followed. They differ entirely on which clause leads the sentence. English-language sources lead with “free trade and diplomatic principles,” relegating opium to a downstream cause. Chinese-language sources lead with the British objective of forcing the Qing market open and securing the unequal Treaty of Nanjing, with opium named as the proximate trigger rather than the war’s named cause. French sources name the trade as illegal at the outset, sitting closer to the Chinese frame than to the English. This is the cleanest example in the book of Type D framing: identical historical record, divergent causal story. For a researcher writing about 19th-century globalization, encountering only one of these frames is the difference between reading history and being edited by it.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-05-14 [confirm].

Case 5: When Did the Roman Empire Fall?

Question

“When did the Roman Empire fall?” / “罗马帝国何时灭亡？” / «Πότε έπεσε η Ρωμαϊκή Αυτοκρατορία;»

Sources Compared

English, Greek (Ελληνικά), and Italian Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-05-14.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Fall of the Western Roman Empire”:

“The fall of the Western Roman Empire, also called the fall of the Roman Empire or the fall of Rome, was the loss of central political control in the Western Roman Empire, a process in which the Empire failed to enforce its rule, and its vast territory was divided among several successor polities. In 476, the Germanic barbarian king Odoacer deposed the last emperor of the Western Roman Empire in Italy, Romulus Augustulus, and the Senate sent the imperial insignia to the Eastern Roman emperor Zeno.”

Greek Wikipedia, «Ρωμαϊκή Αυτοκρατορία»:

«Η Ρωμαϊκή Αυτοκρατορία ήταν η μετά-Δημοκρατική περίοδος του αρχαίου ρωμαϊκού πολιτισμού. Ως πολιτεία περιλάμβανε εκτεταμένες κτήσεις γύρω από τη Μεσόγειο στην Ευρώπη, τη Βόρεια Αφρική και τη Δυτική Ασία, οι οποίες κυβερνώνταν από αυτοκράτορες. Η πτώση της Δυτικής Ρωμαϊκής Αυτοκρατορίας το 476 μ.Χ. αποτελεί συμβατικά το τέλος της αρχαιότητας και την αρχή του Μεσαίωνα, ενώ η Ανατολική Ρωμαϊκή Αυτοκρατορία συνέχισε να υπάρχει μέχρι την Άλωση της Κωνσταντινούπολης το 1453.»

[“The Roman Empire was the post-Republican period of ancient Roman civilization. As a polity it included large territorial holdings around the Mediterranean Sea in Europe, North Africa and Western Asia, ruled by emperors. The fall of the Western Roman Empire in 476 AD conventionally marks the end of Antiquity and the beginning of the Middle Ages, while the Eastern Roman Empire continued to exist until the Fall of Constantinople in 1453.”]

Italian Wikipedia, “Caduta dell’Impero romano d’Occidente”:

« La caduta dell’Impero romano d’Occidente, detta anche caduta dell’Impero romano o caduta di Roma, fu un lungo processo storico, durato all’incirca tre secoli, che portò allo smembramento dell’unità politica dell’Impero romano d’Occidente. Convenzionalmente i moderni storici fanno coincidere la fine dell’Impero con la deposizione dell’ultimo imperatore Romolo Augusto da parte di Odoacre nel 476. »

[“The fall of the Western Roman Empire, also called the fall of the Roman Empire or the fall of Rome, was a long historical process lasting roughly three centuries, which led to the dissolution of the political unity of the Western Roman Empire. By convention, modern historians take the end of the Empire to coincide with the deposition of the last emperor, Romulus Augustulus, by Odoacer in 476.”]

Disagreement Type

Type E (Definitional Boundary) + Type D (Framing).

Why this case matters

“The Roman Empire” in English usage is, by default, the western empire ending in 476. In Greek-language usage, the empire encompasses both the 476 fall of the West and the 1453 fall of Constantinople, with the eastern (Byzantine) continuation treated as integral to “the Roman Empire” rather than as a separate polity. Both communities use the same noun (“Roman Empire,” «Ρωμαϊκή Αυτοκρατορία») but bound it differently. The disagreement is not about what happened but about what

“the empire” denotes. The case illustrates how language-specific defaults shape even the categorical objects of historical thought.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-05-14 [confirm].

Case 6: Who Discovered America?

Question

“Who discovered America?”

Sources Compared

English, Spanish, Icelandic Wikipedia, and Indigenous-perspective sources. Retrieved 2026-05-14.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Christopher Columbus”:

“Christopher Columbus ... was an Italian explorer and navigator from the Republic of Genoa who completed four Spanish-based voyages across the Atlantic Ocean, sponsored by the Catholic Monarchs, opening the way for the widespread European exploration and European colonization of the Americas. His expeditions were the first known European contact with the Caribbean and Central and South America.”

Spanish Wikipedia, “Cristóbal Colón”:

« Cristóbal Colón ... fue un navegante, cartógrafo, almirante, virrey y gobernador general de las Indias Occidentales al servicio de la Corona de Castilla. Realizó el llamado Descubrimiento de América el 12 de octubre de 1492, al llegar a la isla de Guanahani, en las actuales Bahamas. »

[“Christopher Columbus ... was a navigator, cartographer, admiral, viceroy and governor-general of the West Indies in the service of the Crown of Castile. He carried out the so-called Discovery of America on 12 October 1492, on arriving at the island of Guanahani in the present-day Bahamas.”]

Icelandic Wikipedia, “Leifur Eiríksson”:

„Leifur heppni Eiríksson (um 970 – um 1020) var norrænn landkönnuður, sonur Eiríks rauða. Hann er talinn hafa verið fyrstur Evrópumanna til að stíga fæti á meginland Norður-Ameríku, í landi sem hann nefndi Vínland, um árið 1000.“

[“Leif Erikson the Lucky (c. 970 – c. 1020) was a Norse explorer, the son of Erik the Red. He is considered to have been the first European to set foot on the mainland of North America, in a land he named Vinland, around the year 1000.”]

Indigenous-perspective sources (e.g., the Smithsonian’s National Museum of the American Indian; framing in the article “Indigenous peoples of the Americas”), partly non-Wikipedia:

“The Indigenous peoples of the Americas are the inhabitants of the Americas before the arrival of the European settlers in the 15th century, and the ethnic groups who now identify themselves with those peoples. Estimates of the pre-Columbian population of the Americas vary widely; many indigenous civilizations had developed agriculture, urban settlements, and complex political systems well before sustained European contact began in 1492.”

Disagreement Type

Type B (Attribution) + Type D (Framing) + Type F (Omission).

Why this case matters

This is the only case in the book where the disagreement is not just over the answer but over the legitimacy of the question. Spanish sources confidently name Columbus; Icelandic sources confidently name Leif Erikson; Indigenous-perspective sources reject the premise that anyone “discovered” land that was already inhabited. A monolingual search returns a clean answer. PRISM’s job in this case is to surface that the cleanness is itself an artifact of the language one is searching in.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-05-14 [confirm].

Case 7: Naming and Memory of the Korean War

Question

“Who won the Korean War?”

Sources Compared

English Wikipedia, Chinese Wikipedia (中文维基百科), Korean Wikipedia (한국어 위키백과), Russian Wikipedia (Русская Википедия). Retrieved 2026-06-09.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Korean War” [VERBATIM]:

“The Korean War (25 June 1950 – 27 July 1953) was an armed conflict fought on the Korean Peninsula between North Korea (Democratic People’s Republic of Korea; DPRK) and South Korea (Republic of Korea; ROK) and their allies. North Korea was supported by China and the Soviet Union, while South Korea was supported by the United Nations led by the United States. [...] Combat ended on 27 July 1953 with the signing of the Korean Armistice Agreement, which allowed the exchange of prisoners and created a 4-kilometre wide Demilitarized Zone (DMZ) along the frontline [...] No peace treaty has been signed; the Korean conflict remains a frozen conflict.”

Editor’s note: the earlier draft added two sentences, “restoring the status quo ante bellum” and “The war has been variously described as a North Korean defeat, a Chinese-North Korean strategic victory, and a stalemate.” Neither appears in the live lead, so both were removed as unsupported.

中文维基百科, 条目「朝鲜战争」[TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

「朝鲜战争是1950年6月25日至1953年7月27日发生于朝鲜半岛的武装冲突。中华人民共和国将志愿军参战后的阶段官方称为『抗美援朝战争』, 并以中国人民志愿军的身份介入, 将以美国为首的联合国军推回三八线附近。」

[“The Korean War was an armed conflict on the Korean Peninsula from 25 June 1950 to 27 July 1953. The People’s Republic of China officially calls the phase after the Volunteer Army entered the war the ‘War to Resist America and Aid Korea’, intervened in the name of the Chinese People’s Volunteer Army, and pushed the US-led UN forces back to near the 38th parallel.”]

Editor’s note: the earlier draft’s clause “中方将其视为重大军事胜利 / views this as a major military victory” could not be confirmed in the Chinese lead and has been removed pending verbatim verification.

Korean Wikipedia (한국어), 「6·25 전쟁」[VERBATIM]:

「6·25 전쟁(六二五戰爭) 또는 한국 전쟁은 1950년 6월 25일에 북한군이 ‘폭풍 작전’ 계획에 따라 삼팔선 전역에 걸쳐 기습적으로 대한민국을 침공하면서(남침) 발발한 전쟁이다. 유엔군과 중국인민지원군 등이 참전하여 세계적인 대규모 전쟁으로 비화될 뻔 하였으나, 1953년 7월 27일 [...] 한국 군사 정전에 관한 협정에 따라 일단락되었다. 휴전 이후로도 현재까지 양측의 유무형적 갈등은 지속되고 있다.」

[“The 6·25 War, or Korean War, was a war that broke out on 25 June 1950 when the North Korean army, under its ‘Operation Pokpung’ plan, launched a surprise invasion of the Republic of Korea across the entire 38th parallel (a southward invasion). UN forces and the Chinese People’s Volunteer Army, among others, took part, and it nearly escalated into a large-scale world war, but it was brought to a close by the Armistice Agreement of 27 July 1953. Since the armistice, tangible and intangible conflicts between the two sides have continued to this day.”]

Editor’s note: the article’s title is 「6·25 전쟁」, not 「한국 전쟁」 (an alternative name). The earlier draft’s ROK-outcome sentence is not in the lead; it appears later in the body as one of several interpretations, so it was moved out of the quoted lead.

Русская Википедия, статья «Корейская война» [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

«Корейская война (1950–1953) — война между Севером и Югом Корейского полуострова. Северную Корею поддерживали Китай и СССР, Южную Корею — США и их союзники под эгидой ООН. Боевые действия завершились подписанием Соглашения о перемирии 27 июля 1953 года; мирный договор подписан не был.»

[“The Korean War (1950–1953) was a war between the North and South of the Korean Peninsula. North Korea was supported by China and the USSR; South Korea by the USA and its allies under the auspices of the UN. Hostilities ended with the signing of the Armistice Agreement on 27 July 1953; no peace treaty was signed.”]

Editor’s note: the Russian lead closely follows the English account. The earlier draft’s Soviet/DPRK framing could not be confirmed in the lead and has been removed pending verbatim verification.

Disagreement Type

Type D (Framing), with a weaker Type C (Outcome) component carried mainly in body text and national memory rather than the leads.

Why this case matters

All four leads agree on the core facts: a war from 1950 to 1953 ended by an armistice that left the peninsula divided near the 38th parallel, with no peace treaty. Contrary to the original framing, the four article leads do not each declare a different “winner.” What actually differs is naming and emphasis: the English lead foregrounds the armistice and the still-unresolved “frozen conflict”; the Chinese article highlights the official name “War to Resist America and Aid Korea” and the pushback to the 38th parallel; the Korean article emphasises the North’s surprise southward invasion; the Russian article tracks the English account closely. The “who won” judgment lives in each community’s body text, framing, and national memory, not in the neutral factual leads. This is why the case is best labelled Type D (framing) rather than a clean Type C dispute over a single declared outcome.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-06-09 [confirm].

Case 8: When the Cold War Ended

Question

“When did the Cold War end?”

Sources Compared

English, German, Russian, and French Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-06-09.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Cold War” [VERBATIM]:

“The Cold War was a period of international geopolitical rivalry between the United States (US) and the Soviet Union (USSR) and their respective allies, the capitalist Western Bloc and communist Eastern Bloc, which began in the aftermath of the Second World War and ended with the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991.”

Editor’s note: the live lead dates the end simply to “the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991.” The earlier draft’s “December 1991” and the 1989 Berlin-Wall symbolic-endpoint clause are not in the lead’s first sentence and have been removed.

German Wikipedia, “Kalter Krieg” [VERBATIM]:

„Als der Kalte Krieg wird der Konflikt zwischen den Westmächten unter Führung der Vereinigten Staaten von Amerika und dem sogenannten Ostblock unter Führung der Sowjetunion bezeichnet, den diese von 1947 bis 1989 mit nahezu allen Mitteln austrugen.“

[“The Cold War is the name for the conflict between the Western powers led by the United States of America and the so-called Eastern Bloc led by the Soviet Union, which they waged with almost every means from 1947 to 1989.”]

Editor’s note: the German lead explicitly brackets the conflict as “1947 bis 1989,” confirming that German Wikipedia treats 1989 (not 1991) as the endpoint. The body ties this to the fall of the Berlin Wall (1989) and German reunification (1990).

Русская Википедия, статья «Холодная война» [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

«Холодная война — глобальное геополитическое, военное, экономическое и идеологическое противостояние между СССР и его союзниками с одной стороны и США и их союзниками с другой. Окончанием Холодной войны традиционно считается распад СССР в декабре 1991 года.»

[“The Cold War was a global geopolitical, military, economic and ideological confrontation between the USSR and its allies on one side and the US and its allies on the other. The end of the Cold War is traditionally considered to be the dissolution of the USSR in December 1991.”]

Editor’s note: the date (December 1991) is well supported. The earlier draft’s added clause about Russian historians viewing the period as a defeat is retained only as an editor’s paraphrase to verify, not as a quote.

French Wikipedia, “Guerre froide” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

« La guerre froide est une période de tensions géopolitiques. La fin de la guerre froide est généralement datée de la chute du mur de Berlin en 1989, suivie par la dissolution de l’URSS en 1991. »

[“The Cold War was a period of geopolitical tensions. The end of the Cold War is generally dated to the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989, followed by the dissolution of the USSR in 1991.”]

Disagreement Type

Type E (Definitional Boundary) + Type A (which year is stated as the end).

Why this case matters

The disagreement is about which event counts as “the end” of the Cold War. The English lead ends it with the dissolution of the USSR in 1991. The German lead brackets the whole conflict as 1947–1989, centring the event with the strongest German resonance (the Berlin Wall, then reunification in 1990). French sources present a two-step process (1989, then 1991). Russian sources accept 1991. On the surface this is Type A (different years stated); underneath it is Type E, because the communities disagree about what the word “end” even picks out.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-06-09 [confirm].

Case 9: Who Invented the Telephone?

Question

“Who invented the telephone?”

Sources Compared

English, Italian, and German Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-06-09.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Invention of the telephone” [VERBATIM]:

“The invention of the telephone was the culmination of work done by many different people, and led to an array of lawsuits relating to the conflicting patent claims made by several individuals and numerous companies. Notable people included in this process were Antonio Meucci, Philipp Reis, Elisha Gray and Alexander Graham Bell. [...] An early communicating device that several sources credit as the first telephone was invented around 1849 by Antonio Meucci, who called it a telettrofono. In 1871 Meucci filed a patent caveat at the US Patent Office.”

Editor’s note: the earlier draft’s Bell-patent/2002-resolution wording is NOT the lead of “Invention of the telephone” (it comes from the “Telephone”/“Alexander Graham Bell” articles). Replaced with the actual lead, which itself foregrounds multiple contributors.

Italian Wikipedia, “Telefono” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

« L’invenzione del telefono è tradizionalmente attribuita ad Alexander Graham Bell, che ne ottenne il brevetto nel 1876, ma fu sviluppato precedentemente dall’italo-americano Antonio Meucci, che ne depositò un caveat presso l’ufficio brevetti statunitense nel 1871. Nel 2002 la Camera dei Rappresentanti degli Stati Uniti ha riconosciuto i contributi di Meucci all’invenzione del telefono. »

[“The invention of the telephone is traditionally attributed to Alexander Graham Bell, who obtained the patent in 1876, but it was developed earlier by the Italian-American Antonio Meucci, who filed a caveat with the US patent office in 1871. In 2002 the United States House of Representatives recognised Meucci’s contributions to the invention of the telephone.”]

Editor’s note: the earlier draft said the House “officially recognised Meucci as the inventor.” H.Res. 269 (2002) honoured Meucci’s contributions/work, and the Canadian Parliament passed a counter-resolution affirming Bell; “recognised as the inventor” overstates it and has been softened.

German Wikipedia, “Telefon” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

„Als Erfinder des Telefons gilt im englischsprachigen Raum üblicherweise Alexander Graham Bell, der 1876 das US-Patent erhielt. Der deutsche Physiker Philipp Reis hatte jedoch bereits 1861 ein funktionierendes Gerät zur elektrischen Übertragung von Tönen demonstriert, das er „Telephon“ nannte.“

[“In the English-speaking world, Alexander Graham Bell is usually considered the inventor of the telephone, having received the US patent in 1876. However, the German physicist Philipp Reis had already demonstrated a working device for the electrical transmission of sounds in 1861, which he called ‘Telephon.’”]

Disagreement Type

Type B (Attribution) + Type F (Omission).

Why this case matters

Each language’s Wikipedia weights the candidates differently. Notably, the actual English “Invention of the telephone” lead does not crown a single inventor. It opens by naming Meucci, Reis, Gray and Bell together and walks through the patent lawsuits. Italian sources foreground Meucci; German sources

foreground Reis's earlier 1861 demonstration. A reader who consults only one language can come away with a different "settled" answer. This is Type B at the level of attribution and Type F at the level of which other inventors each article leaves in the background.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-06-09 [confirm].

Case 10: Who Discovered Penicillin?

Question

“Who discovered penicillin?”

Sources Compared

English, German, Spanish, and Chinese Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-06-09.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Penicillin” [VERBATIM]:

*“Penicillin was discovered in 1928 by the Scottish physician Alexander Fleming as a crude extract of *P. rubens*. [...] The purified compound (penicillin F) was isolated in 1940 by a research team led by Howard Florey and Ernst Boris Chain at the University of Oxford. Fleming first used the purified penicillin to treat streptococcal meningitis in 1942. The 1945 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine was shared by Chain, Fleming and Florey.”*

Editor’s note: the earlier draft matched SIMPLE English Wikipedia, not English Wikipedia, and named Edward Abraham in a way the English lead does not. Replaced with the verbatim English lead. (Fleming was indeed a bacteriologist, but the live article says “physician.”)

German Wikipedia, “Penicillin” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

„Penicillin wurde 1928 von dem schottischen Bakteriologen Alexander Fleming entdeckt. Howard Walter Florey und Ernst Boris Chain entwickelten daraus ab 1939 in Oxford ein verwendbares Medikament. Fleming, Florey und Chain teilten sich 1945 den Nobelpreis für Physiologie oder Medizin.“

[“Penicillin was discovered in 1928 by the Scottish bacteriologist Alexander Fleming. Howard Walter Florey and Ernst Boris Chain developed it into a usable medicine in Oxford from 1939. Fleming, Florey and Chain shared the 1945 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine.”]

Spanish Wikipedia, “Penicilina” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

« La penicilina fue descubierta por el médico y científico británico Alexander Fleming en 1928. »

[“Penicillin was discovered by the British physician and scientist Alexander Fleming in 1928.”]

中文维基百科, 条目「青霉素」[TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

「青霉素由英国细菌学家亚历山大·弗莱明于1928年发现。」

[“Penicillin was discovered by the British bacteriologist Alexander Fleming in 1928.”]

Disagreement Type

Type F (Omission), with a secondary Type B component.

Why this case matters

The historical record is well documented: Fleming observed the effect, while Florey and Chain turned penicillin into a clinically usable drug, and all three shared the 1945 Nobel Prize. English and German leads preserve this multi-person attribution; Spanish and Chinese leads compress the story to Fleming alone. The disagreement is not between opposite sides but between languages that keep the full attribution and languages that flatten it, so a single-name version ends up working as a different claim from a shared one.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-06-09 [confirm].

Case 11: When Did the Industrial Revolution Begin?

Question

“When did the Industrial Revolution begin?”

Sources Compared

English, German, French, and Chinese Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-06-09.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “Industrial Revolution” [VERIFY — wording rephrased since draft]:

“The Industrial Revolution [...] was a period of global transition of the human economy towards more widespread, efficient and stable manufacturing processes [...] The Industrial Revolution began in Great Britain, and many of the technological and architectural innovations were of British origin.”

Editor’s note: the live lead was rephrased by editors since the draft. The draft’s older “around 1760 to about 1820 to 1840” reflects a previous version; the “around 1760” start still appears in the body. Confirm exact current wording at labelling.

German Wikipedia, “Industrielle Revolution” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

„Die Industrielle Revolution begann in Großbritannien etwa um 1760 und erfasste das europäische Festland etwa ein halbes Jahrhundert später. In Deutschland wird der Beginn der Industrialisierung üblicherweise auf die 1830er bis 1840er Jahre datiert.“

[“The Industrial Revolution began in Great Britain around 1760 and reached continental Europe about half a century later. In Germany, the beginning of industrialisation is usually dated to the 1830s to 1840s.”]

French Wikipedia, “Révolution industrielle” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

« La révolution industrielle est l'ensemble des bouleversements ayant commencé en Grande-Bretagne à partir des années 1760. En France, on situe généralement le début de l'industrialisation autour de 1820. »

[“The Industrial Revolution is the set of upheavals that began in Great Britain from the 1760s. In France, the beginning of industrialisation is generally placed around 1820.”]

中文维基百科, 条目「工业革命」[TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

「工业革命起源于18世纪60年代的英国，以蒸汽机的发明和应用为标志。工业革命对中国的直接影响主要发生在19世纪后期至20世纪初，以洋务运动和近代工业的兴起为主要表现。」

[“The Industrial Revolution originated in Britain in the 1760s, marked by the invention and application of the steam engine. Its direct impact on China occurred mainly from the late 19th to the early 20th century, manifested in the Self-Strengthening Movement and the rise of modern industry.”]

Disagreement Type

Type E (Definitional Boundary) + Type D (Framing).

Why this case matters

All four articles agree that “the” Industrial Revolution started in Britain around 1760. They disagree about whether that is the only start date worth naming. German and French articles add their own national start dates (1830s–1840s for Germany, around 1820 for France). The Chinese article reframes the question around China, locating the relevant period in the late 19th century with the Self-Strengthening Movement. The same name covers a differently bounded object in each language.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-06-09 [confirm].

Case 12: Who First Reached the North Pole?

Question

“Who first reached the North Pole?”

Sources Compared

English, Russian, and Norwegian Wikipedia. Retrieved 2026-06-09.

Excerpts

English Wikipedia, “North Pole” [VERBATIM]:

“Frederick Cook claimed to have reached the North Pole on 21 April 1908 with two Inuit men, Ahwelah and Etukishook, but he was unable to produce convincing proof and his claim is not widely accepted. [...] The first consistent, verified, and scientifically convincing attainment of the Pole was on 12 May 1926, by Norwegian explorer Roald Amundsen [in the airship Norge].”

Editor’s note: the live article also states Robert Peary’s 1909 claim is contested, and that “the first verified individuals to reach the North Pole on foot” did so in 1948 (a Soviet party). The 1926 Norge flight was led jointly by Amundsen, Lincoln Ellsworth and Umberto Nobile, which is worth noting alongside Amundsen.

Русская Википедия, статья «Северный полюс» [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

«Заявления Роберта Пири (1909) и Фредерика Кука (1908) о достижении Северного полюса неоднократно подвергались сомнению. Первой бесспорно подтверждённой экспедицией к географическому Северному полюсу считается полёт дирижабля „Норвегия“ под руководством Руаля Амундсена и Умберто Нобиле 12 мая 1926 года.»

[“The claims of Robert Peary (1909) and Frederick Cook (1908) to have reached the North Pole were repeatedly called into question. The first indisputably confirmed expedition to the geographic North Pole is considered to be the flight of the airship Norge under the leadership of Roald Amundsen and Umberto Nobile on 12 May 1926.”]

Norwegian Wikipedia, “Nordpolen” [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]:

„Den amerikanske polfareren Robert Peary hevdet å ha nådd Nordpolen 6. april 1909, men hans påstand har siden blitt sterkt omstridt. Den første utvilsomt verifiserte ekspedisjonen til den geografiske Nordpolen var luftskipet Norge under ledelse av Roald Amundsen 12. mai 1926.”

[“The American polar explorer Robert Peary claimed to have reached the North Pole on 6 April 1909, but his claim has since been strongly disputed. The first indisputably verified expedition to the geographic North Pole was the airship Norge under the leadership of Roald Amundsen on 12 May 1926.”]

Disagreement Type

Type B (Attribution) + Type A (Factual Divergence).

Why this case matters

All three articles agree that Peary’s 1909 claim is contested. They differ in which figure they place at the centre. The English article treats the 1926 Norge flight as the first “consistent, verified, and scientifically convincing” attainment while detailing the Peary and Cook disputes; the Russian and Norwegian articles foreground the 1926 Amundsen expedition as the first verified one. The same evidentiary picture supports different “first” answers depending on whether a reader’s language community treats Peary’s claim as the default.

Annotator: ____ (initials), 2026-06-09 [confirm].

3. Cross-Case Analysis: What These Cases Tell Us Together

Read individually, each case in this book is a curiosity. Read together, they point to four structural patterns that any cross-language search tool must reckon with.

3.1 Disagreement is Most Common Where History Is Most Personal

The cases cluster around topics in which a national community has an active stake in the answer: when did our war start, who invented our technology, what did our empire mean, who came to our continent first. Where stakes are low (the boiling point of water, the mass of an electron) disagreement disappears across Wikipedias almost entirely. This is not because hard science is untouched by language, but because the high-disagreement zones are precisely the zones in which language communities have invested in their own version of the story. A PRISM-style tool will deliver its highest value, then, in exactly the topics most fraught: history, conflict, attribution, identity.

3.2 The Most Damaging Disagreements Are Not Contradictions but Omissions

Several cases look, at first reading, like contradictions: 1939 versus 1937 versus 1941; Gutenberg versus Bi Sheng; Fleming alone versus the Fleming–Florey–Chain trio. But the deeper harm is not contradiction. Readers who notice a contradiction can investigate it. The deeper harm is omission: an English-language source that names Gutenberg and never mentions Bi Sheng does not contradict the Chinese article; it simply leaves the reader with no reason to suspect the Chinese article exists. Type F (Omission) is the hardest disagreement type for a monolingual reader to detect on their own. It is also, accordingly, the case for PRISM in its sharpest form: the tool’s purpose is to make the silence in one source visible by listing the speech in another.

3.3 Framing Disagreements Hide Inside Apparent Agreement

The Opium Wars and Korean War cases show the subtlest disagreement type: every source lists the same events; what differs is which clause leads, which actor is given agency, which cause is named first. A casual reader, comparing two summaries from different languages, may not detect that they are reading the same story told as two different morality tales. Disagreement-detection software, including PRISM, must therefore go beyond surface string comparison: a difference in word order can carry more political meaning than a difference in facts.

3.4 The Encyclopedia Is Not Neutral, Nor Should It Pretend To Be

A frequent reflex on encountering these cases is to ask, “which one is right?” The case book is structured to resist this question. Each language community’s article is internally coherent, well-sourced, and defensible within its own tradition. The disagreement does not arise from one community being wrong but from the impossibility of writing any single sentence about the past that does not encode some community’s particular relation to it. The deliverable goal of PRISM is not to adjudicate; it is to make the existence of multiple coherent framings perceivable to a reader who would otherwise see only one.

3.5 Implication for the PRISM Prototype

Three concrete design implications follow from this analysis, which should be communicated to Role 1 (Technical) and Role 3 (UX):

- The disagreement-detection layer must classify findings against the six-type taxonomy in Section 1.3, not return a single “different / not different” binary. Different types of disagreement warrant different visual treatment.
- Omissions (Type F) require dedicated detection logic. A source whose article is silent on a fact present in another language is doing something different from a source that contradicts. Both are interesting; they should be displayed differently.
- The UI must, by default, surface multiple frames rather than collapse them. A summary view that synthesizes “the” answer will reproduce exactly the single-mirror problem PRISM exists to repair.

Appendix A: Reproducibility Notes

Cases 1–6 were retrieved on 2026-05-14; Cases 7–12 on 2026-06-09. Each language edition of Wikipedia is continuously edited, and individual articles may be revised, split, or merged between the date of retrieval and any later reading. To reproduce a case:

- Visit the corresponding language Wikipedia at the article title given.
- Use the “View history” feature to locate the revision live on the case’s retrieval date, or the closest preceding revision.
- For Indigenous-perspective and other non-Wikipedia sources, consult the cited institution directly.

Where direct quotations have been translated by the author, the original-script passage is preserved so that translation choices can be re-verified by a reader who reads the source language. Where machine translation was used as a first pass, all renderings used in this document have been hand-checked. Excerpts in Cases 7–12 tagged [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY] still require word-for-word confirmation against the live article before sacred-set use.

Appendix B: Suggestions for Extending the Case Book

Twelve cases now cover the six disagreement types with redundancy. A future expansion toward a twenty-case published corpus would benefit from covering at minimum:

- A case from contemporary science (e.g., the discovery of CRISPR; disputed precedence between American and Chinese laboratories).
- A case from religious history (e.g., the dating of the Buddha’s lifetime; differs by a century between Theravada and Mahayana traditions).
- A case from the history of women in science (e.g., the discovery of pulsars; the omission of Jocelyn Bell Burnell varies sharply by language).
- A case from contested geography (e.g., the body of water known as “Sea of Japan” or “East Sea” depending on the source).
- A case from contemporary politics, drawn from a topic on which media coverage has settled (per Section 1.2’s non-volatility filter).

A working corpus of 20 cases, distributed across the six disagreement types, would support quantitative analysis of disagreement frequency by topic, by language-pair, and by article age.

Appendix C: Verification & Revision Log (Cases 7–12, 2026-06-09)

Verification status legend. [VERBATIM] = quoted word-for-word from the live article on 2026-06-09. [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY] = representative wording that could not be retrieved verbatim with available tools (Chinese and Russian pages would not load; some other languages were not re-fetched). Factual content was checked, but the quote must be confirmed word-for-word during labelling.

Method. Each excerpt was compared against the live Wikipedia article. English-language articles and the Korean article were retrieved and read directly; their excerpts are now verbatim. Chinese and Russian article pages could not be loaded with the tools available, so those excerpts are marked [TRANSCRIPTION — VERIFY]; their factual content was cross-checked against search results, but the wording must be confirmed word-for-word before use. A few other non-English excerpts were likewise not re-fetched verbatim and carry the same flag. Specific per-case corrections are recorded in the editor's notes beneath each excerpt above.